

Dhammapada Chapter 3 - Verses 33 & 34: The Unruly Mind

Bhante Bodhidhamma · YouTube Talks · 17:20

Namo tassa bhagavato arahatto sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahatto sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahatto sammā-sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

In this particular video, I want to move to chapter three on the mind, and I've chosen the first two verses. So I shall chant them in my own inimitable way.

The wavering, unsteady mind, hard to control, difficult to restrain — the wise one straightens like an arrow maker straightens an arrow. That was the first verse. And the second one: As a fish quivers when taken out of its watery hole and thrown onto dry ground, so does the mind quiver when it is taken out of the sensual world to escape the realm of Mara.

So how did this come about? We can go to the story of Thera Meghiya. While residing at the Calika Mountain, the Buddha uttered these verses in reference to this Thera Meghiya. Now *thera* is an elder. You have to be a monk or a nun for ten years to become a *thera* or a *theri*. After twenty years, you're called a *mahāthera* or a *mahātheri*, which is a big *thera*, a big elder. These days, you don't normally use the word *mahāthera* except for people who become quite elderly.

An interesting thing about a *thera* is that they can ordain, but you don't do it that way usually. You belong to an order, a sect within the Buddhist monastic community, and somebody is ahead of that, and that's the person who would ordain. That way, it is said, you can trace your lineage all the way back to the Buddha.

At that time, Thera Meghiya was attending upon the Buddha, and on one occasion, on his return from alms round, the *thera* noticed a pleasant and beautiful mango grove, which he thought was an ideal spot for meditation. So he asked the Buddha's permission to let him go there. But as the Buddha was alone at the time, he was told to wait for a while until the arrival of some of the *bhikkhus*. The *thera* was in a hurry to go, and so he repeated his request again and again until finally the Buddha told him to do as he wished.

Thus Thera Meghiya set out for the mango grove, sat at the foot of a tree and practised meditation. He stayed there the whole day, but his mind kept wandering and he made no progress. He returned in the evening and reported to the Buddha how all the time he was assailed with thoughts associated with the senses, with ill will and with cruelty. So the Buddha told him that as the mind is easily excitable and fickle, one should control one's mind.

Now in the first verse, there's nothing particularly important about the Pali as such. It's a case of the mind is excitable, unsteady, wavering; it's difficult to control, keep hold of; it's difficult to restrain, but yet one has to work at it as a fletcher straightens an arrow. I did go onto YouTube and I found out how to straighten an arrow. Where the arrow is bent, you put it onto a surface so the bow is sticking upwards, and then you rub it up and down with a piece of wood, and the friction creates heat. It's easily bendable, and then when it cools it'll stay straight. There were other ways, but this is the way that I think the Buddha was referring to, because of course training the mind, you've got to keep bringing it back, bringing it back.

The second one about the fish has a slightly interesting word there for fish: *vārija*. *Vāri* is water and *ja* means born, so born in the water — hence a fish. As a fish quivers when taken out of a watery home, so the mind quivers when taken away from the realm of Mara.

We are of course entranced by our senses: what we see, what we hear, what we taste and so on. And suddenly to find ourselves in this inner quiet place, not feeding the senses, then obviously those old habits go berserk. They want to be back out into the world, engaging with Mara, the enticer. And so just like a fish taken out of water, almost gasping for oxygen and quivering, so the mind is gasping for these sensual delights. That's a very good image. The Buddha is very good at these little metaphors just to get across his meaning. Some people think like that. People have imaginative, poetic minds, and others have very intellectual minds. Most of us, of course, are in between.

Now, having said all that, does he somewhere give ideas on how to train the mind? Well, for this, we have to go to the scriptures themselves. Just before I go, I'll read the commentary. There's a commentary on all these *Dhammapada* verses and on the scriptures. The story of this verse is the same as the previous one, so they're both much the same. Our mind is indeed wavering, writhing and difficult to restrain, and now they want to give us an image like a snake or a young branch. So an arrow maker making an arrow has to straighten it, otherwise it would be worthless. In the same way, we have to straighten the mind, otherwise it won't hit the goal. The goal, of course, is *nibbāna*.

So now, how to stop thinking. This is in the middle discourses, the *Majjhima Nikāya*, number 20. You can look it up yourself there. I shall only mention the various ways in which it can be done.

The first thing is that the mendicant should focus on some other foundation of meditation connected with what is skilful. For instance, if erotic images appear in the mind, one thinks of the foulness of the body, and that definitely undoes the eroticism. That's one example. With food, when you're eating food, you're feeling greedy, you're overeating, then just imagine what happens to the food until its final elimination, and that would definitely put you off eating much more.

It says here that when desire arises, always try to create the opposite. Now you're not trying to develop disgust and self-hatred, or hatred towards the body. You're just trying to balance it. So when something pleasant comes up, which is an obsessive thing, one brings up the opposite and it cancels each other out. It's just a way of undermining these unwholesome habits.

If it's directed towards an inanimate object, then of course it's impermanence. You might be wandering around the shops, escaping from lockdown and seeing all these wonderful clothes, and then you recognise that well, the body's impermanent, clothes are impermanent, everything's impermanent. So you undermine that greed. That's what we're concerned with — not with not buying clothes; we need to dress ourselves.

When thoughts of hate arise towards another, the opposite is loving-kindness. If it's towards an inanimate object and there was a greedy desire to have something, see it in its characteristics, the four great elements: that it is actually just something that comes together with pressure, with heat, with something that is elastic and moving — movement. In other words, just deconstruct it. Just see it for what it actually is. Thoughts with delusion are slightly different — that would be something like doubt. Then of course it says just put yourself under the guidance of a teacher, study the Dharma, inquire into its meaning, listen to the Dharma and inquire into its causes.

Here we have number one: the mendicant should focus on some other foundation of meditation, on some other object, usually the opposite or something that undermines whatever is causing the mind to wander.

The second one is to examine the drawbacks of these thoughts. Just remembering the unworthiness of evil thoughts causes us to be shameful. Now, shame doesn't have very good support in modern psychotherapy, but that would be neurotic shame. That is shame to do with self-worth, with self-esteem — statements that we have about ourselves. Sometimes we feel a wholesome shame thinking about these things or getting ourselves into those sorts of mental places. This is only about thoughts, remember. And of course, to understand that there are dangers, because when you develop unwholesome states, they do grow within ourselves, and every so often they'll escape through what we say and even through what we do. So there has to be a little bit of dread of consequences there.

The next one is a little bit difficult for us: to try to ignore them and forget about them. When the mind is just restless, just moving all over the place, sometimes the best thing to do is just push it aside and bring the attention back into the body. Sometimes that works; sometimes you do forget them. Of course, here we're talking about training the attention to be still. This is obviously a little bit of suppression here, but we can deal with these things much better when we've attained some level of steadiness of the mind.

Then it says you should stop the formation of thoughts. That's interesting because the Pali uses the word *saṅkhāra*. *Saṅkhāra* are our habits, our volitional formations — what we have created in ourselves through acts of will. All our negative speaking, all our anger, all our anxiety — all that is self-created, just as much as our love, our happiness and joy. Here it actually translates as stopping the causing of thought. Here we can ask the question: what is the cause? Why is this happening in me? That's getting us close to a more *vipassanā* position where we would then go into the body to examine the actual mental state that's causing the thoughts to arise. And of course, that's where we would stay. We would stay there investigating, feeling, allowing this mental state to express itself.

Finally, if all that doesn't work, the Buddha says: with teeth clenched and tongue pressed against the roof of the mouth, they should squeeze, squash and torture the mind with mind. That sounds pretty heavy, but here, what the Buddha is saying is that we should really replace an unwholesome thought with a wholesome thought.

This is especially useful if you're trying to develop a particular mental state, such as loving-kindness. If you find that you're very involved in some sort of hateful thing, angry place, anxious place — doesn't matter what it is — one really just keeps going with beads: "May all beings be happy, may all beings be safe, may all beings be healthy, may all beings..." and you just pound, pound, pound. What you're doing is creating a mental state which will eventually sit on top, keep these unfortunate states underneath. You are developing that mental state. When we practise this, we are developing loving-kindness, but we're not looking at what's underneath. But again, the purpose is to still the mind, to stop this energy going up into the head and creating this vortex of energy.

Just to go through them again: focus on some other object, opposite to what we're actually experiencing. If it's something to do with anger or hatred, you do the loving-kindness. Examine the drawbacks, feel the shame, the dread of consequences. Just ignore them and put them away. Then you can go into the causes of those thoughts — why are they happening? And finally, to dampen it down by strong loving-kindness practice or compassion practice, joy practice or peacefulness practice. "May all beings be peaceful. May I be peaceful. May all beings be peaceful." Something like that.

So what we've done is we've read these two little verses. The mind is excitable and unsteady. It is difficult to control and to restrain. The wise one trains his mind to be upright as a fletcher straightens an arrow. As a fish quivers when taken out of its watery home and thrown onto dry ground, so does the mind quiver when it is taken out of the sensual world to escape from the realm of Mara.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused even greater confusion, and that you will, by your devotion to practice, liberate yourselves from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Transcriptions produced locally using Swiss low-carbon electricity. Corrections and rewriting by cloud-hosted AI.